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appears that the majority of this book focuses upon social commentary rather than social research. In itself, this does not present the reader with any problem—although it may not strike those with strong research interests as a particularly important work—as long as the authors do what they say they intend to do. On the other hand, difficulties quickly arise when some of the authors state their intention to draw on relevant research but only cite a mere handful of studies in substantive areas that have been the focus of an enormous amount of empirical attention for many years (e.g., divorce). Social commentary is no doubt a worthwhile pursuit, but it does not constitute research and to confound the two is a disturbing tendency that is revealed on several occasions in *Rethinking Marriage*.

In sum, this book is comprised of essays on marriage as the intersection of the individual and society. An examination of marriage as the most significant social crossroad in everyday life is an interesting and potentially useful angle from which to approach the topic. If conducted in a balanced fashion, an informative volume could have been written. By excluding a significant empirical component, however, this book adds little to our understanding of contemporary marriage. One of the contributors observed, during a discussion of marital fidelity, “In my view, psychotherapy is closer to literature than it is to social science. . . .” (p. 76). Unfortunately, from the perspective of a social scientist, the same thing could be said for most of this book.

DUANE W. CRAWFORD
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The Evolution of Desire: Strategies of Human Mating. David M. Buss. New York: Basic Books. 1994. 240 pp. ISBN 0-465-07750-1. \$22.00 cloth.

David Buss has written a very thoughtful book on mating relationships from an evolutionary perspective. The 10 chapters cover the developmental course of relationships, desires that women and men want from relationships, attracting a partner, forming and maintaining relationships, and sexual conflict/dissolution of relationships. While Buss concludes with a chapter on harmony between the sexes, he acknowledges that much of human mating is unpleasant, writing, “In the ruthless pursuit of sexual goals, for example, men and

women derogate their rivals, deceive members of the opposite sex, and even subvert their own mates” (p. 5).

The premise of the book is that human behavioral characteristics have evolved because of their reproductive as well as survival benefits. The emphasis on sexual selection is used as a context for understanding gender differences in sexual strategies and relationship goals, as well as how these change within a lifetime of males and females. The balance between ontogeny as well as phylogeny makes the contents more relevant for understanding human behavior change. There is an equal treatment of strategies of males and females because both are critical to the evolutionary equation. According to Buss, males do not compete for passive women, but both genders contribute to a social milieu from which relationships develop, and in fact, they depend on each other for passing genes on to future generations. While the primary focus is on sexual behavior, family structure and parenting are incorporated into the book through discussion of male commitment to assist in raising children.

At least a rudimentary understanding of evolutionary principles is helpful but not necessary for the reader. As is often the case in evolutionary psychology, Buss integrates research related to mating behavior primarily from the domains of social psychology, anthropology, and life-span developmental psychology. He illustrates his points using current research with the human species, animal analogues, and the popular media in a very striking fashion. For example, when discussing sneak or satellite sexual strategies used by some males, consecutive paragraphs focus on an illustrative example from a Woody Allen movie, survey data obtained from college campuses, and comparative data on sunfish from the lakes of Ontario. As another example, his discussion of mate-switching integrates research on spotted sandpipers (a polyandrous shorebird) with observations of Donald Trump’s portrayal in the media. These transitions are often smooth and creative, and they certainly maintain the reader’s attention. Buss even uses illustrations of behavioral strategies (e.g., “a Friday night in the bar”) that gives an interesting (if not unsettling) context for reader introspection about his or her own current and historical behavior within relationships.

Domestic violence, sexual jealousy, relationship difficulties, and adultery are common issues for individuals working with couples and families. I read the book during media coverage of the

"O. J. Simpson story," which is alleged to contain these very issues, and in fact, may have riveted North America's attention in the summer of '94 for these reasons. Buss claims that understanding why sexual strategies have developed and what functions they were designed to serve provides a powerful fulcrum for changing behavior. For the graduate student, researcher, and family practitioner, there is considerable substance in this well-written and thought-provoking book.

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The Military Family in Peace and War. Florence W. Kaslow (Ed.). New York: Springer Publishing. 1993. 277 pp. ISBN 0-8261-8270-4. \$39.95 cloth.

Florence Kaslow assembles an engaging set of chapters that capture the way in which both demands and supports within the United States military setting, and structural changes in society, frame and inform family structure and functioning. An underlying aim of the volume is to provide practitioners who work with military families insights into the special character and culture of life in the military, and an appreciation for how broader structural and normative aspects of military life permeate, shape, and constrain the nature of marital and family system dynamics. Kaslow considers such a contextual perspective imperative in the training and supervision of clinicians who work with military families.

The volume consists of 13 chapters, and is divided into two parts. The first part includes seven chapters that review a number of personal and interpersonal issues that shape patterns of personal and family adaptation to the demands of military life, including an integrative chapter by Kaslow on "Attitudes, Knowledge Base, and Skills Essential to Treat Military Families." Other chapters in this section (a) describe the special stressors on children in military families; (b) review policies, trends, and stereotypes about women and mothers in the military, especially the issue of women in combat; (c) provide follow-up research on the long-term adjustment of Vietnam-era children with a father missing in action; (d) discuss the diagnosis and treatment of psychosexual dysfunctions that are associated with combat stress; (e) reinforce the importance of cognitive factors in the adaptation process of military families; and (f)

capture the character and lifestyle of "special warriors," operators whose military duty is performed in a shroud of secrecy and whose families are called upon to make special sacrifices.

Part 2 of *The Military Family* broadens the focus of the volume to show how the military family is embedded in a larger social structure that influences the timing of life cycle transitions and that provides an array of benefits and health and social services to promote successful adaptation of service members and their families to the rigors of military life. Six chapters are included in Part 2, including an integrative concluding chapter by Kaslow. This final chapter reemphasizes the encompassing nature and special stressors of military service on service members and their families, and the need for practitioners who treat these families to have a contextual appreciation for the challenges that these families face in balancing work and family demands. This chapter is preceded by chapters that (a) review the history, development, and preventive and interventive functions of family service centers in each of the service branches; (b) explain how service members and their families may be affected by war-related deployments, offering recommendations for how practitioners can assist them in coping with stressors that are associated with separation, reunion, and war-related disorders; (c) describe the interface between the military family and the health care system for military beneficiaries, emphasizing the role of the family in influencing health behaviors and outcomes; (d) examine the special challenges that are associated with military retirement, especially in the context of military downsizing; and (e) review the planning and development of social policies that inform the structure and mission of the military in contemporary society, including a discussion of selective social issues that are the foci of proposed legislation.

Despite its strengths, the volume is not without some limitations. From the perspective of this reviewer, the volume lacks an overarching summary framework that effectively frames its contents and that results in both a policy and program agenda, as well as research agenda, for the remainder of the 1990s. While no volume can accomplish everything, it is unfortunate, as the editor notes, that chapters on certain controversial social issues—such as gays and lesbians in the military—are not included. While the chapter reviews are generally good, some chapters would have been strengthened by a more exhaustive literature review.